EMUNOT VEDEOT: SAADIAH GAON'S BOOK OF BELIEFS AND OPINIONS

Where Is Olam HaBa in the Torah?

Emunot VeDeot, Essay 9:2

Sefer: Emunot VeDeot (The Book of Beliefs and Opinions) by Rav Saadia Gaon

Essay/Chapters: Essay 9 (Olam HaBa, The World to Come), Chapter 2

Shiur: Part of Dayan Daniel Kada's Monday series on Emunot VeDeot, Monday 8 September 2025, on Zoom

These notes are based on a transcript of the recording.

Recap: Where Essay 9 Begins

Last week the series resumed with an overview of the first eight essays and an introduction to Essay 9, which is all about **עולם הבא**, the World to Come. In Rav Saadia's scheme, Olam HaBa comes **after** Mashiach, after techiyat hametim, after the Beit HaMikdash and that whole period. Then a new world begins, in which all the promises are fulfilled. Essays 7 and 8 dealt with techiyat hametim and Mashiach; now the focus is "the real afterlife, the real world to come, the eternal one."

Chapter 1 gave proofs **from reason** that there must be an afterlife, "some quite compelling, some different":

- **Justice.** How can HaKadosh Baruch Hu create a world with no justice? We see the wicked prospering and the righteous suffering. What of children who suffer?
- **This world is full of suffering.** A God who is entirely good would not create only this. "Quite a pessimistic view of the world."
- **Restlessness.** People Saadia had met are never really at peace, because they know there is something else.

The plan for tonight

Chapter 2 moves to the second source: **the pesukim**. Where in Tanach do we find the concept of Olam HaBa? In the middle of this, Saadia digresses with a question: why is Olam HaBa only **hinted** at in the Torah, never mentioned explicitly? That question, with the answers of the Rishonim, would take up most of the shiur.

Saadia promises **thirteen** proofs from Scripture: six in this chapter and seven in the next. Chapter 3 would wait for another week.

Six Proofs From Tanach

Proof 1: Those who gave up their lives

Yitzchak. The Midrashim say that at first Yitzchak did not know what was going to happen at the Akeidah. But at some point he recognised he was to be sacrificed, and he gave himself up. Only at the last moment did the angel intervene. Saadia asks: if consequences and reward exist only in this world, what was Yitzchak expecting? "You die, that's the end." And Hashem, who is just, would not have commanded it.

Chananyah, Mishael and Azaryah threw themselves into the fiery furnace rather than worship the idol (Daniel 3). "I'm throwing myself into the fire, I'm going to burn, I'm going to die. What am I going to get afterwards?" They must have believed something awaited them.

Daniel, caught praying in defiance of the king's decree, was thrown to the lions (Daniel 6). What was he expecting?

All of these show that the righteous and the prophets agreed that **the reward is in the next world**. One could bring many stories from the Gemara, but Saadia finds his examples in Tanach itself.

Why not Avraham?

A participant asked why Saadia does not mention **Avraham** being thrown into the fire. Because, the Rabbi answered, that is not explicit in Tanach. The fire of Ur Kasdim, and Haran trying to copy Avraham, are lovely, but they are Midrashim. Saadia's examples are explicit stories in the Nevi'im. "Saadia is the master, really the master of Tanach. Everything he manages to find a source from Tanach for." And, the Rabbi added, "I'm sure what has stood out for all of us over the last two years is he loves numbers. Everything is always numbered. Six this, seven that, ten this."

Richard's challenge: obedience alone

Richard asked: could Yitzchak not simply have accepted that this was what was required of him?

The Rabbi first answered from Saadia's side. Yitzchak was an adult. "If my father was trying to kill me and I didn't believe in anything after my death, I would fight back." Avraham, by contrast, proves nothing: he could think that by obeying Hashem he would have a wonderful future in this world. But Yitzchak was going to die.

Then he developed Richard's point. In the Tuesday Rambam shiur the week before, the class had focused on the **highest level of service**: you do the truth **because it is the truth**, you serve Hashem because that is the right thing and nothing else. Serving Hashem for reward is fine, a good service, "it's not the perfect, not the ultimate. The ultimate is you do the will of Hashem because it is the will of Hashem."

"If you take that approach, I think Rav Saadia's proof completely falls away." Yitzchak could say: there is no future and no world to come, but Hashem told me to do it, it is the right thing, full stop. "If you take the Rambam's view of reward and punishment, there's no proof here. The Rambam would never suggest a proof like this."

Masada

The argument has been used in history. **Josephus** records that **Elazar**, who led the defenders of Masada, told them exactly this in his speech before the end: the main reward is in the World to Come, so why should we be afraid of death?

Saadia's Question: Why No Explicit Mention?

Before the next proof, Saadia digresses. Look through the Torah and all you find is reward and punishment **in this world**. "No further do you have to look than this week's parashah, Parashat Ki Tavo." On Shabbat, in shishi, it would be read quietly: "two and a half pages of terrible things happen if you don't keep My mitzvot and half a page of wonderful things happen if you do." The Torah, Hashem and Moshe all seem to speak about this world. Why?

Of course there are hints, says Saadia, but it is not explicit, for two reasons. The Rabbi read them first and promised to examine them later.

Answer 1: Reason already knows it

Things that **reason requires** the Torah does not dwell on at length, and the afterlife can be deduced by reason, as Chapter 1 showed. But things that are less logical, like the punishments of this world, the Torah must spell out.

Saadia's example is the first commandment to Adam:

מכל עץ הגן אכל תאכל. ומעץ הדעת טוב ורע לא תאכל ממנו (Bereishit 2:16-17)

From every tree of the garden you may eat, but from the tree of knowledge of good and bad you shall not eat.

Why did Hashem not command Adam not to murder, not to commit adultery, not to steal? **Because reason teaches all these.** But the tree of knowledge cannot be deduced, so it had to be commanded. So too reward in the World to Come: the Torah did not mention it because reason teaches it.

"I think some of us are probably thinking it's a pretty weak answer." The Rabbi raised two points:

1. **Saadia contradicts himself.** In **Essay 3**, on Torah and revelation, Saadia insisted that even **rational mitzvot** must be revealed. Don't murder: what happens if you do, and what is the framework? Don't commit adultery: what counts as adultery? Don't steal: what counts as belonging to someone? He went into great detail to show these must be taught. "And yet here he's saying the logical things don't need to be taught."
2. **The Gemara behind it.** Saadia clearly has in mind the Gemara in **Sanhedrin**, which derives the **seven Noahide laws** from the words of the command to Adam, **ויצו ה' אלהים על האדם**: "and He commanded" refers to courts; "Hashem" to cursing God; "Elokim" to idolatry; "on the man" to murder; and so on. So the laws are hinted at in the pasuk, but only the tree of knowledge is stated explicitly, because only it is not logical. That is exactly Saadia's point about Olam HaBa.

Answer 2: The Torah speaks to the present

The Torah and prophecy generally focus on **what is needed now**, and say less about what lies far ahead. When the Torah was given, "we're becoming a nation, we're entering the land." The people needed to know what would happen there: do what I ask and you will have rain, produce and peace; if not, war. So the Torah elaborated on that and only hinted at the World to Come. "That's something in the future, so worry about it when it comes."

Back to the Proofs

Proof 2: Moshe Rabbeinu

"One of the greatest proofs." Over and over the Torah promises rain in the land, produce, peace and all the beauty of living in Eretz Canaan. **Moshe never received any of it**; he never entered the land. If the only reward is what is promised explicitly, Moshe, the greatest of all, should surely have received it. So the real reward must be in the World to Come.

Proof 3: Eliyahu and Elisha

Eliyahu blessed the widow of Tzarfat, telling her to fill her vessels, and she had flour and oil (Melachim I 17), yet he did not have such things for himself. **Elisha** was dead and buried, and when a dead man was thrown into his grave and touched his bones, the man came back to life (Melachim II 13:20-21). Elisha was dead and yet could give life to another.

If everything were about this world, how could someone give another what he does not have himself? "If I don't have money, how can I give money to someone else?" But if Eliyahu and Elisha have a great reward in the World to Come, then they can give in this world what they cannot receive in it.

Proof 4: Sedom

The Torah tells us that Sedom did terrible things and was destroyed. That would mean every city that commits the same atrocities should be destroyed, "take for example cities nowadays committing atrocities." It does not happen. So their retribution must come in the next world.

You could ask in brackets: then why was Sedom punished in this world? "You don't know Hashem's calculations. Sometimes this world, sometimes the other world. That's acceptable."

Proof 5: Exile

When Bnei Yisrael sinned, served other gods or behaved badly, Hashem exiled us. Other nations also serve idols and do terrible things, and they are not exiled. If everything were in this world, they should receive the same. So it must come in the World to Come. "Again, you can refute this proof and say Bnei Yisrael are different, more was expected of us, but fine."

Proof 6: Children

Hashem commands terrible things, such as the killing of children. The class had read in **Parashat Matot** a couple of weeks earlier of the children of Midian killed by Bnei Yisrael; and there were the children who died in the Flood. "We see nowadays lots of children suffering." How can that be fair? There must be **compensation in the World to Come**.

The class had seen this argument in an earlier essay. The Rambam took issue with it and "didn't like it at all," but Saadia holds that children who suffer or are killed while innocent receive recompense for it.

Summary of the six proofs

#	Proof	The point
1	**Yitzchak, Chananyah, Mishael, Azaryah, Daniel**	Why give up your life if this world is all there is? (The Rambam would not accept this proof)
2	**Moshe Rabbeinu**	The greatest of all never received the Torah's promises
3	**Eliyahu and Elisha**	They gave others what they did not have themselves
4	**Sedom**	Other wicked cities are not destroyed in this world
5	**Exile**	Other idolatrous nations are not exiled
6	**Children**	Innocent suffering must be compensated

Chapter 1 gave six proofs from logic; Chapter 2 six proofs from characters and events in Tanach.

Mark: Moshe's forty days

Mark suggested a hint Saadia did not use: **Moshe's forty days on the mountain** without food. In Olam HaBa there is no physicality; we sit with Hashem and learn. Isn't that a taste of the World to Come?

The Torah does say explicitly that Moshe ate no bread and drank no water. The **Ramchal**, for example, uses it as a model of what Olam HaBa is about: sitting with Hashem with no physicality. And Saadia himself will link it to Olam HaBa in a coming chapter. But the Torah does not say it was bliss or the ultimate reward. "Remember, Moshe wasn't going up for reward." He went up to receive the Torah, and the second and third times it would have been better had he not needed to. "You can connect the concept to that, but to prove there is such a concept from it I think is a bit difficult." Mark agreed it was not a proof.

The Rishonim on Saadia's Question

"Saadia is the first one to ask this question. We've seen this over and over again: Saadia was the trailblazer in philosophical questions which were discussed by the Rishonim later on." Many Rishonim took up this question, and the **Abarbanel**, Don Yitzchak Abarbanel of 15th-century Spain, gathered their answers together. The Rabbi planned to go through the Abarbanel over this shiur and the next.

The passage comes at **the end of Bechukotai**, the first set of blessings and curses, "but it's actually perfect timing for this week," since Ki Tavo has the second set. It is a very long passage, and the Rabbi read selected parts. The Abarbanel writes that everyone asks why the rewards in the Torah are all physical, with no mention of anything after death. He has already

brought many proofs from the Prophets for reward and punishment after death, but the question remains. He has gathered **seven answers**, naming the author of each.

The class's suggestions

Before reading, the Rabbi asked: based on the Tuesday Rambam shiurim, what would the Rambam answer?

Flora suggested that if we knew for certain about the reward of the World to Come, we might do the mitzvot only to get the reward, and not with emunah and sincerity. "That was excellent what you said," the Rabbi said. "Half you answered."

Another participant suggested that perhaps there is no reward in the World to Come at all, and we are just told so to make us behave. "No, I'm sorry, I can't accept that." Belief in Olam HaBa is **explicit** in our Chachamim, mentioned throughout, and supported by the proofs from logic and Torah the class had seen. "The question isn't whether we believe in it or not." We believe in it; the question is only why the Torah does not mention it explicitly.

The Rabbi also wished **Maria** mazal tov on her son's wedding that week, and dedicated the shiur to the success of the couple.

Answer 1: The Rambam, "There Is No Reward in the Torah"

The Rambam says, as the class had learned about a year earlier: you have misunderstood. The good and bad things the Torah promises **are not reward and punishment** at all. The reward is ultimate bliss and connection with the Almighty, as a person develops their consciousness and spiritual identity by working on themselves and becoming the best version of themselves in this world. The blessings and curses are means:

- If you go on the path of wanting to serve HaKadosh Baruch Hu, Hashem says: "I'll give you your money, I'll give you your produce on time, so you'll be able to focus and to pray and to study. I will take away your enemies; you won't have to fight."
- If you do not want that, Hashem puts **impediments** in your way, such as wars, illnesses and famine, and you are distanced even further from your perfection.

The Rabbi gave a current example. "Look at now. Two years we've been in Gaza." A good friend of his told him his beit midrash is almost empty, because most of the religious reservists are away fighting. "We don't want that. That's a curse. We want to be able to sit in the beit midrash and to study, and we can't." That is what the Rambam means: if we were all doing the right thing, Hashem would give us the conditions to develop and focus. "It's not reward and punishment. You missed the point."

So why is reward mentioned neither in this world nor in the next? Because the Torah does not want it to be **the focus**. Do the truth because it is the truth; do it out of love because it is the right thing. "We don't keep the mitzvot because of reward and because of punishment." This, the Abarbanel says, is the opinion of the Rambam in Sanhedrin and the Mishneh Torah. The Abarbanel has questions on it, which the Rabbi did not go into; "the Abarbanel wasn't a fan of this view." But it is the first answer: **you asked the wrong question.** "Clearly it's not Saadia's answer."

Answer 2: The Ibn Ezra, "Too Deep for Most People"

"A bit of a patronising answer, but also makes a lot of sense," and it ties in with the previous week's Rambam shiur.

Spiritual reward is **a deep matter, hard to grasp**. What is Olam HaBa? Eternal bliss, yes, connection with Hashem, devekut, as in the Ramchal and the Rambam. But for most people these are hard to understand, "and even for us, we're still very limited in what that means."

The Rabbi's analogy: you could spend all day trying to explain to someone blind from birth the difference between red, purple, green and yellow. "Where am I going to start? I've never seen colour before." So too, "stuck in our body in this physical world, how much can I tell you about what Olam HaBa is? We know very, very basic things."

The Ibn Ezra continues: **the Torah was not given to the wise alone**, but to people of every age and both genders. Because most people's understanding is weak, the Torah gives them things that are tangible. The wise recognise the real thing from the hints; for them it is "just an opening to the real thing, which is Olam HaBa."

Albo's question

Rabbi Yosef Albo asks: the Torah does ask us to move beyond physical thinking, even when it is hard. We are all physical, and yet we are commanded to **negate physicality from Hashem**. So why not tell us the World to Come is not physical either?

The answer: one is negative and one is positive. "I can command you: negate physicality from God. What exactly is God, I can't tell you, but I can tell you He is not physical. I can define God through negatives." To describe Olam HaBa **positively**, to say what it is, is impossible. "It's something too spiritual."

Summary and Looking Ahead

- **Chapter 2:** six proofs from figures and events in Tanach that there is an Olam HaBa.
- **Saadia's question**, asked for the first time: why is Olam HaBa not mentioned explicitly? His answers: reason already teaches it, and the Torah speaks to the needs of the present.
- **The Rambam:** there is no reward or punishment in the Torah at all, only supports and impediments; the Torah does not want reward to be the focus.
- **The Ibn Ezra:** Olam HaBa is too deep to explain to most people, so the Torah gives tangible promises and only hints at it for the wise.

The third answer, the **Ramban's**, would come next week, with a closer look at Saadia's answers and the views of the **Kuzari**, **Rabbi Yosef Albo**, the **Ramchal**, the **Maharal** and contemporaries including **Rabbi Sacks**.

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